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Geopolitics, Local Politics and America's Role in the Middle East Peace Process

Robert J. Lieber

The United States plays by far the most important role of any external power in the contemporary Middle East. To some degree, this has been the case for more than four decades, but the American role has become even more pronounced in the years since the end of the Cold War, with the dissolution of the Soviet Union and the defeat of Iraq in the Gulf War. These events have minimized the Russian role in the region, which had been of major importance during the Cold War, while lessening the impact of rejectionist states. Moreover, since at least 1967, and despite the passage of time and profound changes at both global and regional levels, the United States has followed relatively consistent policies toward the Middle East. In general, it has sought to sustain the moderate Arab oil-producing countries of Saudi Arabia and the Gulf, contain threats from revisionist powers (as in the case of dual containment of Iran and Iraq), support the security of Israel with diplomatic, military and economic assistance, and promote the Arab-Israeli peace process.

The relative prominence and durability of the American Middle East role poses conceptual questions at least as significant as those surrounding the post-Cold War European

role of the United States in sustaining and widening the Atlantic Alliance rather than withdrawing from it. A lessening of America's Middle East regional involvement might have been anticipated, but this has not happened. Explanations for the sustained American role abound, though with widely varied rationales and subject matter. Some observers have found the answers for current (and past) policy to lie primarily in domestic politics and thus to anticipate no policy change in the absence of shifts within the United States itself. Other explanations have tended to emphasize the importance of the Cold War and the effort to counterbalance the Soviets during that time, and thus anticipated a reduction in the U.S. commitment to the region. However, the American role has been maintained and fundamental changes in post-Cold War American policies in the Middle East have not taken place.

In an effort to provide a more robust understanding, this paper emphasizes neither present events and controversies nor diplomatic history. Instead, it concentrates upon broader structural and strategic causes that have shaped American policy and it then considers the interplay of these factors with the American domestic context. While domestic politics play a significant role (as they do in most foreign policy matters), the sustained involvement and policies of the United States are a consequence of systemic factors and of American vital national interests in the region. Protection of these interests as well as regional stability depend in substantial measure on a continued U.S. role, both in the Arab-Israeli relationship and in the Gulf. As a consequence, it is not surprising that there has been continuity in American policy.

1. Geopolitics and the Strategic Environment

In the post-Cold War world, far from pulling back after the ending of the Soviet threat, the United States has not only maintained its Middle East role, but even expanded and intensified it. This was evident in the leadership of the Bush administration in organizing Operations Desert Shield and Desert Storm after Saddam Hussein's August 1990 invasion of Kuwait, as well as in its convening of Israeli and Arab leaders

at the Madrid Conference in October 1991.

In its turn the Clinton administration has continued with an active Middle East regional role, taking the lead in containing Saddam and in maintaining the No-Fly Zones and other restrictions on his regime, as well as in including Iran its policy of dual containment and in deploying some 20,000 military personnel (mostly from the U.S. Navy) in and around the Gulf.

At the same time, the U.S. has continued to play a leading role in the Arab-Israeli peace process. Although the 1993 Oslo agreement was initiated by the Rabin Government and the PLO, with Norway providing the quiet venue for negotiations, the consummation of this effort took place in Washington, with the signing of the Declaration of Principles on the South lawn of the White House on September 13, 1993. The setting provided not only an American imprimatur for this historic agreement, but also direct evidence of the U.S. commitment to and involvement in the peace process. Subsequent steps, including the Jordanian-Israeli Peace Treaty of October 26, 1994, the Israeli-Palestinian Interim Agreement on the West Bank and Gaza (Oslo II) signed by Rabin and Arafat on September 28, 1995, and the Hebron Agreement of January 17, 1997 involved an intimate U.S. role and in the case of the Israeli-Palestinian measures would not have been consummated without the critically important American effort in helping the parties to bridge their often bitter disagreements and distrust.

Nor do the above involvements exhaust the list of recent and current American activity. In the aftermath of terrorist bus bombings and other attacks within Israel conducted by Hamas and Islamic Jihad in early 1996 and aimed at disrupting the peace process, the Clinton administration organized an unprecedented anti-terrorism summit on March 13, 1996. While this "Summit of the Peacemakers" was more symbolic than substantive, and meant to signal support for the peace process and opposition to terror, it was remarkable for the presence of leaders from 27 countries, including 12 from the Arab

world, who had been brought together through the strenuous efforts of the United States.

In addition, with the objective of supporting the peace efforts economically, the U.S. has continued to provide some \$13 billion per year in aid to Israel, \$2 billion to Egypt and much smaller amounts to Jordan and the Palestinians. In the military realm, the United States embraced Israel in 1987 as a major non-NATO ally, established joint anti-terror working groups in 1996, and linked Israel with the American missile warning system in 1997.

The extent of American commitment is even evident in unsuccessful diplomatic efforts. Thus, in Clinton's first term, from 1993 to 1996, Secretary of State Warren Christopher made no fewer than 24 trips to Damascus in fervid (though ultimately disappointed) pursuit of a Syrian-Israeli agreement. The priority accorded to this effort was remarkable. According to figures provided by the State Department in May 1996, the Secretary of State had made at least 26 trips to Israel, 24 to Syria, and 13 to Egypt. There is no doubt that the Middle East was worthy of high-level attention, though the Secretary's visits to Syria alone far outnumbered those he made to four of the most important countries in the world combined: Russia(6), Japan(4), Germany(4) and China(1).¹

This pattern of activity and commitment to the region rests on a strategic logic. The fundamentals are spelled out in a Department of Defence posture statement for the Middle East issued in 1995. This sets out three criteria for determining whether a foreign danger affects vital U.S. interests:

- (i) if it threatens the survival of the United States or its key allies;
- (ii) if it threatens critical U.S. economic interests;
- (iii) if it poses the danger of a future nuclear threat.

"Nowhere," the report observes, "are these criteria met more clearly than in the Middle East."²

These criteria quite clearly apply both to the Arab-Israeli context, where they are reflected in American commitments to Israel, Egypt and Jordan, as well as to the peace process, and to the Gulf, where support for Saudi Arabia and the dual containment of Iran and Iraq have been evident.

While events in the region have often been tumultuous, it is important to note that strategic imperatives have shaped American policy in the region for more than four decades. In the recent past these interests have included not only access to oil, but also concern about weapons of mass destruction and deterrence of threats to friendly countries. Though, from an historical perspective, the commitment to Saudi Arabia can be traced back to the administration of President Franklin Roosevelt in the early 1940s.

The conventional wisdom concerning U.S. policy toward Israel has long held that it was not until the 1962 Kennedy administration's decision to sell Hawk anti-aircraft missiles that American policy changed and became more favourable towards Israel. It has been similarly maintained that the change in policy was driven by domestic politics and that after the 1960 presidential election in which John F. Kennedy narrowly defeated Richard Nixon, such considerations outweighed more hard-headed and long-standing calculations of America's strategic interests in the region. This interpretation emphasises the role of ethnic groups within the Democratic Party, not least that of Jewish and pro-Israel groups in key states in Washington.

In a new study based on important archival material, however, Avi Ben-Zvi has demonstrated that the origins of the policy shift actually can be found in the Eisenhower administration, as a result of its gradual recognition of changes in the region, especially after the July 1958 crises in Lebanon, Iraq and Jordan. Particularly in the case of Jordan, Israel showed itself to be the sole staunchly pro-western power in the region. The change in policy thus occurred not primarily because of domestic American politics, but because of geopolitical factors and a recognition that Israel could be a

strategic asset to the United States instead of burden.³ In making the case for this interpretation, Ben-Zvi quotes a very explicit August 1958 letter from Secretary of State John Foster Dulles to Israeli Prime Minister David Ben-Gurion:

"The heart of the matter...is the urgent necessity to strengthen the bulwarks of international order and justice against the forces of lawlessness and destruction which currently are at work in the Middle East. We have been glad that Israel shares this purpose, as illustrated by your deeply appreciated acquiescence in the use of Israel's airspace by United States and UK aircraft in their mission in support of Jordan...We believe that Israel should be in a position to deter an attempt at aggression by indigenous forces, and are prepared to examine the military implications of this problem with an open mind...The critical situation in the Middle East today gives Israel manifold opportunities to contribute, from its resources of spiritual strength and determination of purpose, to a stable international order."⁴

In another study, Kenneth Organski has reached conclusions consistent with those of Ben-Zvi concerning the basis for U.S. policy towards Israel as ultimately resting more on foreign policy reasons than on domestic politics. In Organski's analysis:

U.S. policy decisions with respect to Israel have, in the main, been made by presidents and presidential foreign policy elites both by themselves and for reasons entirely their own. When the U.S. did not see Israel supporting U.S. interests in stemming the expansion of Soviet influence, it did not help Israel...When U.S. leaders...decided that Israel could be an asset in the U.S. struggle with radical Arabs who were perceived as Soviet clients, they helped Israel.⁵

While the shift towards a closer U.S.—Israeli strategic relationship had its origins as far back as 1958, the United States initially took only modest and tentative steps. The

relationship expanded slowly and then deepened after the Six Day War of 1967 and especially after the Yom Kippur War of 1973. As evidence of this, a recent study has shown that while American foreign aid to Israel amounted to \$3.2 billion in the years from 1949 to 1973, it grew to a total of \$75 billion for the period from 1974 to 1997.⁶

II. "Local" Politics

Within the United States, the years since the end of the Cold war have brought a sharply diminished sense of foreign threat. Indeed, the years since 1990 represent the first time in more than half a century that the country has not faced a compelling foreign challenge to its security and vital interests. This lessening of the sense of foreign threat and crisis that fascism, World War II and the Cold War represented has tended to reduce the importance accorded to foreign policy and to some extent to undercut the degree of executive power and authority available to the presidency. In this sense, there has been a reassertion of the Madisonian dimensions of the American political system,⁷ with their elements of separation or powers, checks and balances, federalism, and other restraints on the erstwhile "Imperial Presidency."⁸

Not suprisingly, these factors have resulted in a significant decrease in the attention and priority accorded to foreign affairs. Public attention and interest in the subject has declined, as has coverage in the media. For example, one recent study found that network television nightly news programme coverage of foreign stories has declined by more than half in the years from 1989 to 1996, from 3,733 minutes to 1,829 minutes.⁹

American politics and elections have seen substantially reduced attention to foreign policy as well. In the 1992 presidential election contest, foreign policy occupied only a minimal place in the Clinton campaign, and on election day only 9% of voters indicated that foreign policy was one of the two most important issues influencing their vote for president.¹⁰

In the 1994 congressional elections, in which the Republicans gained control over both houses of Congress for the first time in forty years, foreign policy played even less of a role, and the subject was only minimally evident in the Republican "Contract with America."

In turn, foreign policy was less visible in the November 1996 Presidential election than at any time in the past sixty years. During the second televised debate between President Clinton and the Republican nominee, Senator Robert Dole, there was only one real question dealing with foreign affairs, and that concerned trade policy. On election day, no more than 4% of voters nationwide indicated that foreign policy mattered most in deciding how they voted, and in the all important state of California the number citing foreign policy was less than 1%. Thus, it would be a considerable exaggeration to suggest comprehensive thinking about Middle East policy for the second term has preoccupied the White House.¹¹

More broadly, with the end of the Cold War and the dissolution of the Soviet Union, the sense of foreign threat and thus of the importance of foreign policy has sharply diminished in American public life. The U.S. remains inescapably engaged in foreign affairs, but the priority of the subject has diminished—as is evident not only in opinion polls and in reduced news coverage, but a sharp drop in congressional travel abroad, and a 50% reduction in foreign affairs budgets over the past decade. Domestic politics and budget constraints tend to dominate the presidential agenda and to overshadow foreign policy concerns. While this reduced concern about the post-Cold War world has made more difficult the elaboration and sustaining of coherent foreign policies, Americans have not become isolationist. This is evident, for example, in the fact that isolationist candidates lost in both the 1992 and 1996 presidential primaries.

At the same time, the Middle East does remain a partial exception to the lessened priority for foreign policy. Security imperatives and threats to American interests do remain more evident in the region than elsewhere. Moreover, when

domestic and foreign priorities correspond, the result can be strong public and congressional support for administration policy. This is evident in the Middle East and Persian Gulf, where domestic public and interest group sympathies have been broadly congruent with American national interests. In addition, the Clinton administration's key foreign policy decisionmakers provide a great deal of continuity, with Secretary of State Madeleine Albright, National Security Advisor Samuel Berger and their staffs both experienced and also closely identified with long-standing administration Middle East policies.

An authoritative quadrennial study of American public and elite opinion on foreign policy provides empirical confirmation of the relative stability of domestic attitudes toward the Middle East. Among the public at large, 64% identify a U.S. "vital interest" with Israel, not far behind Great Britain (69%) and Germany (66%). For their part, "Leaders" interviewed for the study responded even more favourably. Over the four year period between 1991 and 1995, there was little change in American public opinion toward Israel, with the country continuing to be considered a key ally in the Middle East. Indeed, among elites during the same period, there was actually a substantial increase (to 86% from 78%) in the vital interest response.¹²

Though relations between the United States and the government of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu have been marked by significant and sometimes acrimonious policy disagreements since the coming to power of the Likud government in June 1996, the main lines of U.S. policy toward the region and the peace process have remained in place.

III. America's Role in the Middle East Peace Process

In view of the significantly reduced salience of foreign policy within the post-Cold War United States, the ability of the U.S. to maintain an active and engaged role in the region and in support of the peace process might seem open to question. However, the vital interest criteria cited above,

including the potential perils of war, terrorism, nuclear proliferation, oil supply and threats to friendly countries, provide considerable impetus for sustaining a long-term role. Domestic politics reinforce this orientation, as do the views of most senior policymakers.

The interests and security of the United States tend to benefit from sustaining of the Middle East peace process. Moreover, regional stability is widely understood to require a continued American role in the region. Since 1948, the United States has played a key role in almost every effort to mitigate conflict. Ceasefires, disengagement agreements, tacit understandings, negotiations, and peace agreements have been brokered by the United States. While none of these events could have come about without the agreement of the parties, the legacy of conflict, distrust and profound differences of interest make it difficult for both sides to reach agreement without the presence of the United States to help in bridging their differences.

No other country or institution has been capable of fulfilling that role. Other countries (France, Russia, Britain) have generally been seen by the Israelis as too indulgent or sympathetic to their Arab adversaries and unwilling or unable to work effectively in maintaining agreements among the parties. The limited impact of the individual European countries is further reduced by a free-rider problem, i.e., since the United States is commonly understood to be prepared to incur the necessary costs of maintaining regional stability, deterring threats, leading efforts to deal with terrorism and combating proliferation of weapons of mass destruction, a number of European states have been active in seeking contracts, export markets and arms sales among pariah countries. A more sophisticated German policy of "critical dialogue" with Iran (which also maintained significant commercial opportunities) ultimately proved untenable as a result of the "Mykonos" case when, in the spring of 1997, a German court identified several Iranian defendants, including high officials of the Iranian government, in the 1992 assassination of four Kurdish opposition figures at a Berlin

restaurant. This outcome proved an embarrassment to the Bonn government and left its Iran policy at an impasse.

Major limitations also affect the Middle East role of the European Union. Though it has become a commercial and trading superpower with considerable integration of its member states' national economies, its efforts at common foreign and defence policy have been ineffective and incoherent. Despite their combined wealth and size, the countries of the European Union lack both the commonalities of view and the institutional basis for a coordinated foreign policy. This has been evident consistently, not only in their Middle East efforts, but also closer to home in Bosnia.

For its part, the United Nations has not been able to play an effective Middle East role either. It has had a lengthy record of indifference and sometime hostility toward Israel, as embodied in the General Assembly's infamous "Zionism is racism" resolution, adopted in the aftermath of the 1973-74 oil crisis and not repealed until 1991 following the end of the Cold War and the defeat of Iraq in the Gulf War.

The United States, on the other hand, has played a unique role, not only because of its long record of support for Israel, but also because Israel's adversaries have understood that no other country or organization can operate as an effective interlocutor with the Jewish state. Constraints on American involvement, however, may depend less on policy disagreements (and these have sometimes been quite serious when Israel has had Likud governments), than on domestic budgetary pressures. Though the nominal value (in current dollars) of US aid to Israel and Egypt has been more or less sustained over the past decade, its value in constant dollars has declined, and there is little prospect that the political process in the United States can make available significant additional sums of economic assistance. As a result, aid to Jordan and to the Palestinians has been very modest, even though the U.S. has embraced both actors as they moved to implement peace agreements with Israel. This is a product of the domestic budget debate, tensions between the Democratic

President and a Republican Congress, pressures to reduce the deficit, and competing claims for scarce federal financial resources at a time when there is great pressure to reduce federal spending. Future agreements thus are very unlikely to be accompanied by the scale of American support made available to Egypt and Israel after their peace treaty of March, 1979. Palestinians, Lebanese and Syrians may all have hopes for such largesse, but the domestic American policy environment makes it almost unimaginable that aid on that scale can be forthcoming.

Added to this domestic restraint there is the now lengthy experience with foreign aid to countries of the developing world. This has produced the conclusion that, on average, aid does not have a sustained positive impact on economic growth unless it is accompanied by suitable policies within the developing country itself.¹³ In this regard, the record of most Arab states has not been one that would appear to make such aid effective.

On the other hand, as the experience of the 1990-91 Gulf crisis and war makes clear, only the United States has the capacity to intervene effectively and to act as a leader or catalyst for the involvement of other countries. The evidence from that conflict (as well as from cases outside the region such as Somalia, Haiti and Bosnia) is that the alternative to American led efforts generally is not action led by some other outside power or international or regional organization. Instead it is inaction. When the US opts to exercise leadership, and when that can be sustained domestically, it is often possible to stimulate the necessary response from other external and regional actors. When the U.S. is unable or unwilling to exercise that role, however, effective external action becomes far less likely.

IV. Conclusion

In sum, American vital interests remain fundamentally at stake in the Middle East, and no viable alternative to U.S. leadership exists in dealing with the principal problem areas:

the Arab-Israeli peace process, the stability of the Persian Gulf, and containment of rogue states and the threats they pose of terrorism, weapons of mass destruction, and challenges to moderate regimes. Domestic American politics remain relevant, though in ways largely consistent with long-standing policies more or less supportive of Israel and the peace process and hostile to rejectionist regimes.

Domestic politics thus tends to reinforce the main elements of American policy, though with two limitations. First, budget pressures function to constrain the availability of additional funds to sustain and expand the peace process and to create incentives for cooperative behaviour among regional actors. This constraint may be mitigated to some extent by the extraordinarily strong performance of the American economy and the rapidly dwindling level of the federal budget deficit. However, foreign aid remains deeply unpopular, and the general limitation is likely to persist.

A second domestic constraint involves American military intervention and sensitivity to casualties. This inhibits the commitment of troops to situations of potential combat, though the issue is more pertinent to the Gulf than the Arab-Israeli arena. Nonetheless, as Bruce Jentleson has shown in examining cases of American military intervention during 1980s and 1990s, public support for military intervention has been available when the main objective has been to coerce foreign policy restraint by an aggressor state, when there has been a clear military strategy, and when the policy has been made a priority by the President and Congress, rather than as primarily for dealing with problems of instability or nation-building.¹⁴

The above factors operate at a macro-level. Insofar as the peace process itself is concerned, more specific events, policy problems and choices, and personalities all can have considerable impact as intervening variables. For example, since the Hebron agreement of January 1997, which was a product of active American involvement, and a part of which, the "Note for the Record," and was actually signed by the

United States rather than by the Israeli and Palestinian leaders, the American role has been less conspicuous.¹⁵ This is a product both of regional difficulties and of other foreign priorities. Both the Netanyahu government and the Palestinian Authority under Yasir Arafat have proved to be difficult partners with whom American policy makers have had trouble working effectively. Internal dynamics on both sides exacerbate these cooperation problems, as do actions that contravene the letter or spirit of the Oslo agreements.

For the United States, the difficulty of gaining agreement on implementing both interim and final status measures has temporarily lessened the willingness to intervene more actively, as has the example of Secretary of State Warren Christopher's fruitless trips to Damascus. In addition, the priority accorded to NATO enlargement, China, Bosnia and other pressing matters in the second Clinton term have further reduced the temptation to intervene more actively.

Nonetheless, severe deterioration of the peace process threatens not only regional stability but American national interests, and thus there remain imperatives for the U.S. to continue an active role. Sustaining this involvement depends on a sense of urgency and on regional events, as well as on specific policy choices. While renewed American initiatives may be both desirable and possible, given the gaps between the parties and the inability or unwillingness of the Palestinian Authority to prevent violence, these are most likely to be effective if they reinforce the Oslo agreements and the step-by-step process of Israeli-Palestinian accommodation,¹⁶ rather than initiate dramatic new measures. What remains fundamental, however, is that the U.S. role is primarily neither a product of personal whim nor domestic politics, but of long term strategic and geopolitical imperatives.¹⁷ Over the long term, it is these factors that tend to determine the extent and duration of the American role in the Middle East peace process.

Endnotes

1. Source: *The Economist*, June 8, 1996, p. 28. Indeed, due to criteria used by the State Department, the published data may actually undercount the number of times the Secretary landed in Damascus.
2. Source: Department of Defence, Office of International Security Affairs, "United States Security Strategy for the Middle East," Washington, DC, May 1995, p. 5.
3. Abraham Ben-Zvi, *Decade of Transition: Eisenhower, Kennedy, and the Origins of the American-Israeli Alliance*. Unpublished manuscript, Department of Political Science, Tel Aviv University, 1997.
4. Dulles' letter of August 1, 1958, quoted by Ben-Zvi, unpublished manuscript, Chapter 3, p. 76.
5. Kenneth Organski, *The \$36 Billion Bargain: Strategy and Politics in U.S. Assistance to Israel* (NY: Columbia University Press, 1990), p. 27.
6. Mitchell G. Bard and Daniel Pipes, "How Special is the U.S.-Israel Special Relationship," *Middle East Quarterly*, Vol. IV, No. 2 (June 1967), p. 43.
7. For an elaboration of this point concerning the reassertion of the Madisonian elements of the American political system after the Cold War, see Robert J. Lieber, "Eagle Without a Cause: Making Foreign Policy Without the Soviet Threat," in *Eagle Adrift: American Foreign Policy at the End of the Century* (NY: Longman, 1997), pp. 3-25.
8. The reference is to Arthur M. Schlesinger, Jr., *The Imperial Presidency* (New York: Houghton Mifflin, 1973).
9. Data from the *Tyndall Report*, as cited by Garrick Utley, "The Shrinking of Foreign News: From Broadcast to Narrowcast," *Foreign Affairs*, Vol. 75, No. 2 (March/April 1997): 2-10, at p. 2.
10. Source: Voter Research & Surveys. Election day poll conducted by a consortium of CBS, NBC, ABC and CNN.
11. This and portions of the following two paragraphs are based on Robert J. Lieber, 'U.S. Middle East Policy in the Clinton Second Term; MERIA, *The Middle East Review of International Studies*, Issue No. 1, January 26, 1997. Internet journal published by the Begin-

Sadat Centre for Strategic Studies, Bar Ilan University, Israel, <http://www.biu.ac.il/SOC/besa/meria.html>.

12. John F. Riley (ed.), *American Public Opinion and U.S. Foreign Policy*, (Chicago Council on Foreign Relations, 1995), pp. 20 and 26.
13. A London School of Economics study of 92 countries found that "no relationship exists between the levels of aid and rates of growth in recipient countries" and that government aid tends to discourage removal of barriers to private investment while "increasing the size of recipient governments and lining the pockets of elites." *Forbes*, March 11, 1996, p. 193. Economist Peter Boone directed the study for the National Bureau of Economic Research. Quoted in Walter A. McDougall, "Back to Bedrock: The Eight Traditions of American Statecraft," *Foreign Affairs*, Vol. 76, No. 2 (March/April 1997), p. 134.
14. Bruce Jentleson, "Who, Why, What and How;" also see Jentleson, "The Pretty Prudent Public: Post-Vietnam American Opinion on the Use of Military Force," *International Studies Quarterly*, Vol. 36, No. 1 (March, 1992): 49-73.
15. Israeli and Palestinian officials signed the Protocol on Hebron, but the accompanying Note for the Record, describing a series of understandings, was signed by Ambassador Dennis Ross at the request of Prime Minister Netanyahu and Yasir Arafat.
16. See, for example, the assessment of Richard N. Haass, "The Middle East: Making Oslo Work," *Brookings Policy Brief*, No. 19 (Washington, DC: The Brookings Institution, July 1997).
17. For an analysis of the way strategic imperatives have interacted with personal choices in an important Middle East case, see, Avner Yaniv and Robert Lieber, "Personal Whim or Strategic Imperative? The Israeli Invasion of Lebanon," *International Security* (Fall 1983).